

Handmade
in Bangladesh



NEGOTIATING PATRIARCHY

A Film by

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SPEAKER ONE

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- **Paradox:** a person or thing conflicting with **preconceived** notions of what is reasonable or possible, contrary to accepted opinion.
- Bangladesh achieved major **social progress** despite:
 - Extreme poverty & patriarchy
 - Political instability
- This outcome **contradicted dominant development theories**. Achievements were **pro-poor and gender-equitable**.
- 'Bangladesh stands out as the shining new example in South Asia of a poor country achieving impressive gains in gender equality' (World Bank 2008, p.3).



Three Dimensions of the Bangladesh Paradox

1. Economic Dimension

- Conventional theory suggests social progress depends on reaching a minimum level of economic wealth (*growth-mediated model*).
- Bangladesh challenges this view by achieving strong outcomes in **health, education, and gender equality** despite low per capita GDP.
- Performs better than many richer countries on key social indicators.
- Recognised internationally as a “**positive outlier**” in development outcomes.



2. Political Dimension

- Good governance is usually seen as essential for pro-poor development.
- Bangladesh's state is often characterised as **weak, corrupt, and clientelist**.
- Despite this, the country pursued **policy-supported pathways** that improved social outcomes.
- Collaboration among **government, NGOs, donors, and the private sector** compensated for state weaknesses.

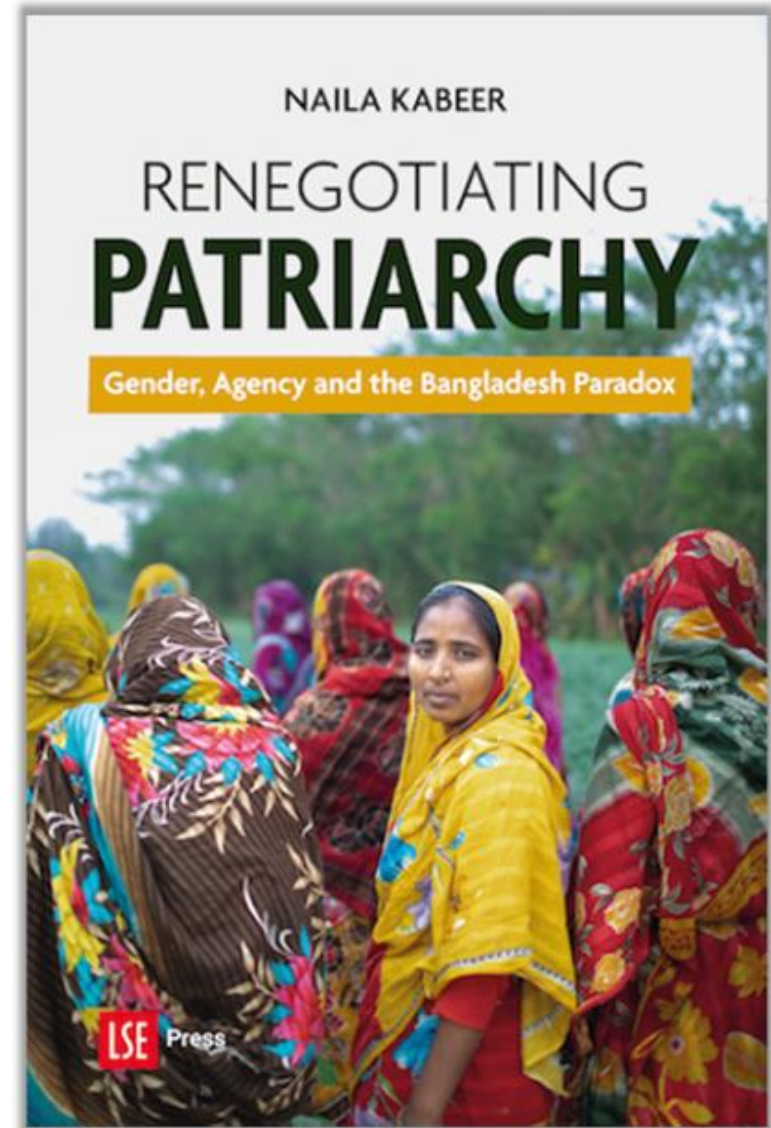


3. Cultural (Gender–Religion) Dimension

- Modernisation theory often views Islam as incompatible with women's emancipation.
- Bangladesh contradicts this assumption: **gender equality improved** alongside a rise in conservative Islamic influence.
- Progress in women's education, health, and labour participation continued.
- Challenges the idea of a “clash of civilizations” over gender norms.



- **High fertility** was mainly driven by son preference, not by a general desire for large families.
- The study highlighted the role of patriarchal social and economic structures in shaping **fertility behavior**.
- Conducted **18 months** of fieldwork in **Amarpur village(pseudonym) in Faridpur district**.
- Designed her own household surveys.
- Lived in the village for over a year.
- Gained deep insight into rural life and social realities.



Bangladesh Compared to India & Pakistan – Key Social Indicators (Drèze and Sen (2013))					8
Indicator	Bangladesh	India	Pakistan	Key Insight	
Fertility Rate (2011)	2.2	2.6	3.4	Bangladesh reduced fertility the most despite starting higher in 1950	
Life Expectancy Trend	Started lowest (1950); overtook India (2000); caught up with Pakistan (2010)	Improved steadily	Improved steadily	Bangladesh showed the fastest improvement	
Female Life Expectancy (2011)	70 years	67 years	66 years	Highest among the three	
Male Life Expectancy (2011)	68 years	64 years	64 years	Higher than both India & Pakistan	
Infant Mortality (per 1000, 2011)	37	47	59	Lowest infant mortality rate	

Gender & Child Mortality Patterns

- **India:** Persisting excess female mortality and rising sex-selective abortion; sex ratio at birth increased to 105:100 to 111 (male:female)
- **Pakistan:** Some rise in sex ratio at birth, but less dramatic than India.
- **Bangladesh:**
 - Gender gaps in infant and child mortality largely disappeared by 2000.
- Sex ratio at birth remained stable at the global norm (105: 100).
 - No shift toward “death before birth” strategies



Decline in Son Preference (Bangladesh – Amarpur Study)

- Fertility rates declined in line with national trends.
- Preference for large families decreased.
- Strong decline in son preference.
- Most families now prefer **balanced sex composition** (both sons and daughters).
- Some respondents even expressed preference for daughters.



Social Change Across Generations

- Older generation recalled extreme poverty and insecurity after independence.
- All generations recognised significant positive social change.
- People saw themselves as active participants in change (“keeping up with changing times”).
- Decisions were shaped not only by cost–benefit logic but by wider societal transformations.
- Shifts observed in:
 - Gender relations
 - Parent–child relations
 - Community norms



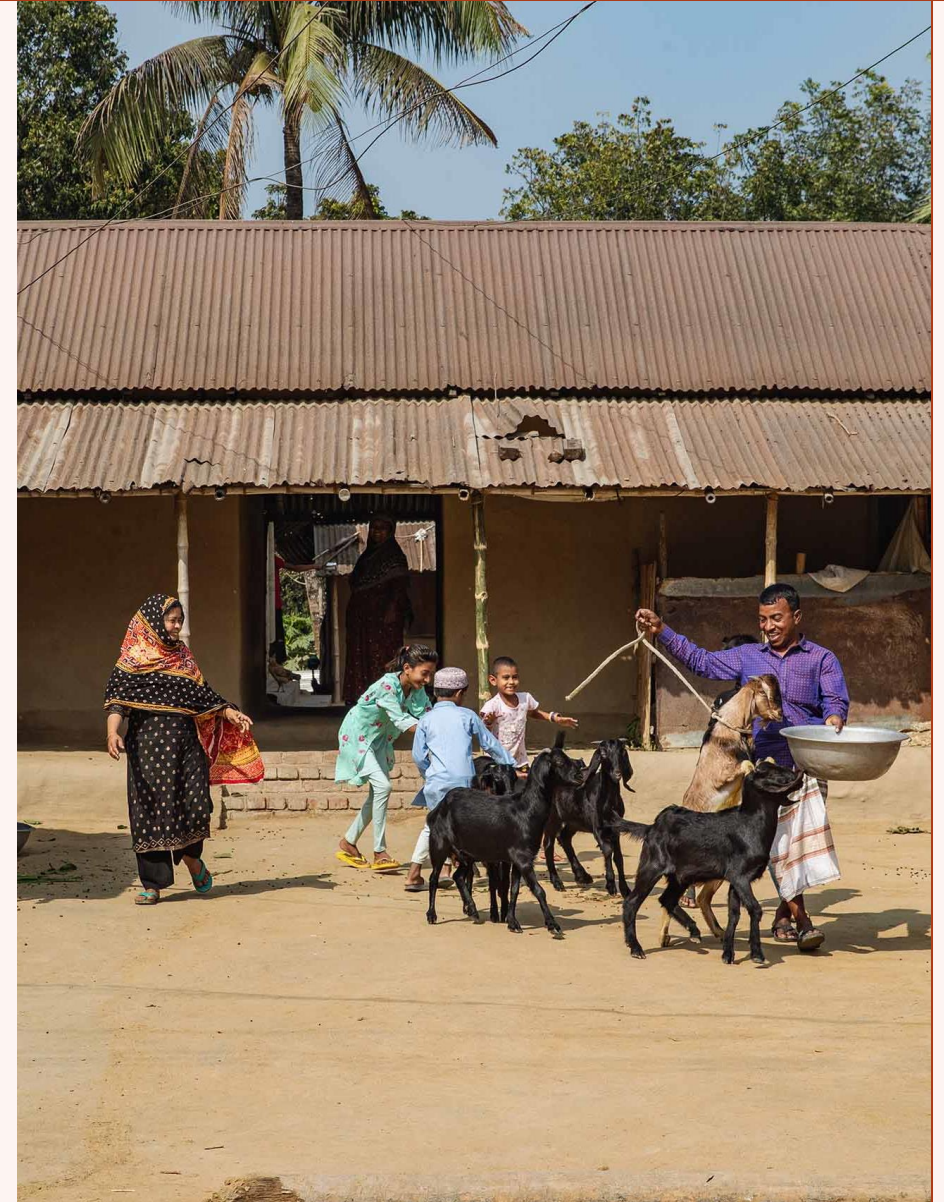
Central Role of Women's Agency

- Widespread belief that women now exercise greater control over their lives.
- Women actively negotiating better futures for themselves and their children.
- Daughters increasingly central to family aspirations.
- Indicates deep structural change in patriarchal norms.
- Women's agency is presented as a **key driver of the Bangladesh paradox.**



Overall Conclusion

- Bangladesh experienced a **fundamental shift in patriarchy**, not just economic improvement.
- Decline in discrimination against girls occurred without rise in sex-selective abortion.
- Social transformation is closely linked to **women's agency and changing aspirations**.
- The Bangladesh paradox cannot be explained by economics or governance alone —
Gender transformation is central to understanding the country's success.



- Women actively:
 - Made fertility decisions
 - Invested in children's education
 - Entered paid and unpaid work
 - Negotiated household norms
- These everyday actions **translated policy into reality**
- **Agency:**
The capacity to define goals and act within constraints.



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THE BELT OF CLASSIC PATRIARCHY

A broad region stretching from:

- North Africa
- Middle East
- Northern South Asia

Societies share **similar family and kinship structures**

- Women experience particularly strong restrictions

Features:

- **Extended Families** (multi-generational).
- **Patrilineal** (inheritance through the father).
- **Patrilocal** (wives live with husband's family).
- **Patriarchal** (men hold power).
- **Endogamous** (marriage within the same group).
- **Polygyny** (sometimes one man has multiple wives).
- **Impact:** Extreme gender discrimination → "Missing women"



- Southeast Asia:**

- Women can inherit property, maintain ties with birth families, and participate in the workforce (agriculture/trade).

- Sub-Saharan Africa:**

- Women can inherit land and actively participate in the labor force.



North India (Indo-Aryan model):

- **Patrilineal kinship**, strict caste rules.
- Women's roles are controlled, and economy participation is limited.
- Early marriages, high fertility, and high maternal mortality.

South India (Indo-Dravidian model):

- More flexible kinship, women have inheritance rights.
- Greater freedom in marriage, movement, and economy participation.
- Less focus on female chastity.



- **Patriarchy** affects women's freedom and influence (called *agency*).
- **South India:** More freedom for women → More equality in families.
- **Other regions:** Limited mobility and economic roles → More gender discrimination.
- **Sen (1990b):** Working outside the home → More respect and fairer share of household resources.



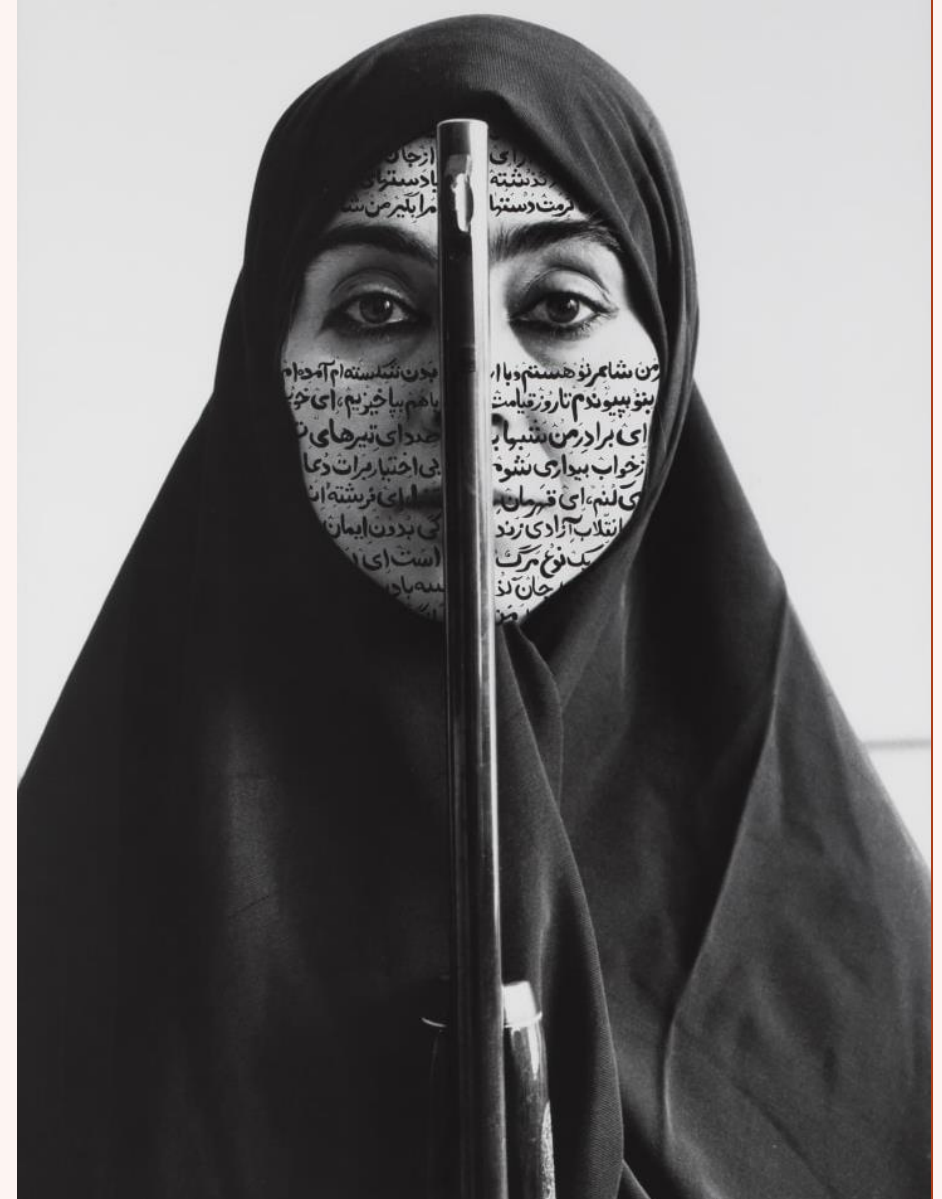
- **Drèze & Sen (1995):** In India, women's work and literacy → Lower fertility, better child survival.
- **Economic Activity** and **literacy** reduce child mortality and improve women's status.
- **Male literacy** had a smaller impact on these outcomes.

- **Kandiyoti (1988):** *Patriarchal bargains* – How women negotiate within societal constraints.
- **In Africa:** Women have more independence and property rights → Challenge authority.
- **In Bangladesh (Classic Patriarchy):** Women's roles are restricted, focusing on having sons → High fertility and son preference.
- **Hypothesis:**
 - **Shifts in Patriarchy:** More economic roles → Reduced dependency and increased value.
 - **Bargaining Power:** Economic opportunities → Better treatment and more equal household resources.



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- Patriarchy is **not a single, uniform system**
- Societies differ in:
 - Degree of control over women
 - Opportunities for women's action
- These differences shape gender and demographic outcomes
- **Key term – Patriarchal regime:**
A structured system of gender relations that defines power, roles, and constraints.



- Research shows consistent links between:
 - Women's agency
 - Fertility decline
 - Child survival
 - Gender equality
- Agency mediates the effects of structure
- **Key term – Agency:**
The capacity to define goals and act upon them within social constraints.

Again from this part of we get the quation , “Structures shape women's choices, but do not fully determine them.”



- Where women engage in productive work:
 - Their contributions become socially visible
 - Their value within family and society rises
- Where women are confined to domestic roles:
 - Discrimination is normalized

Key term – Female economic participation:

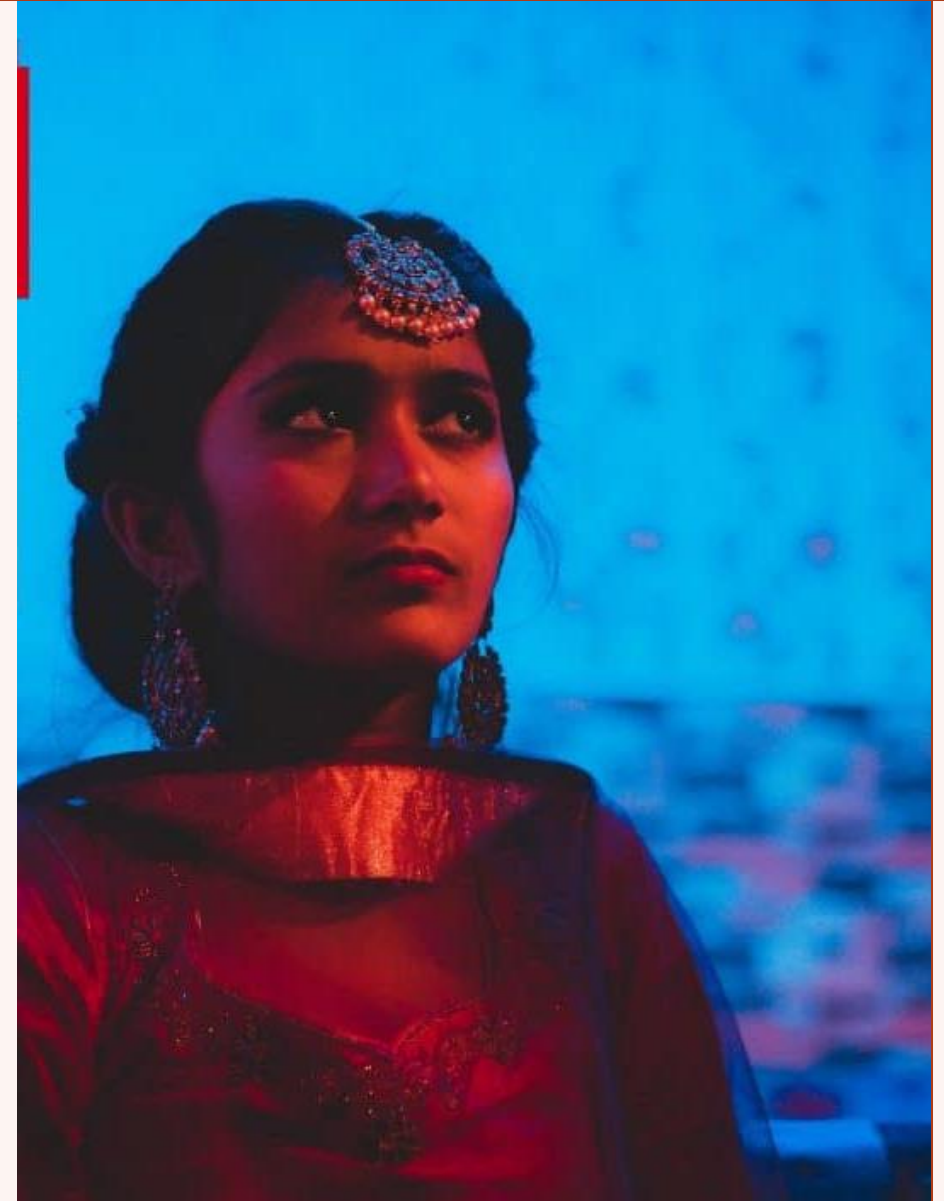
Women's involvement in productive or income-earning activities.

• **Quote-worthy:**

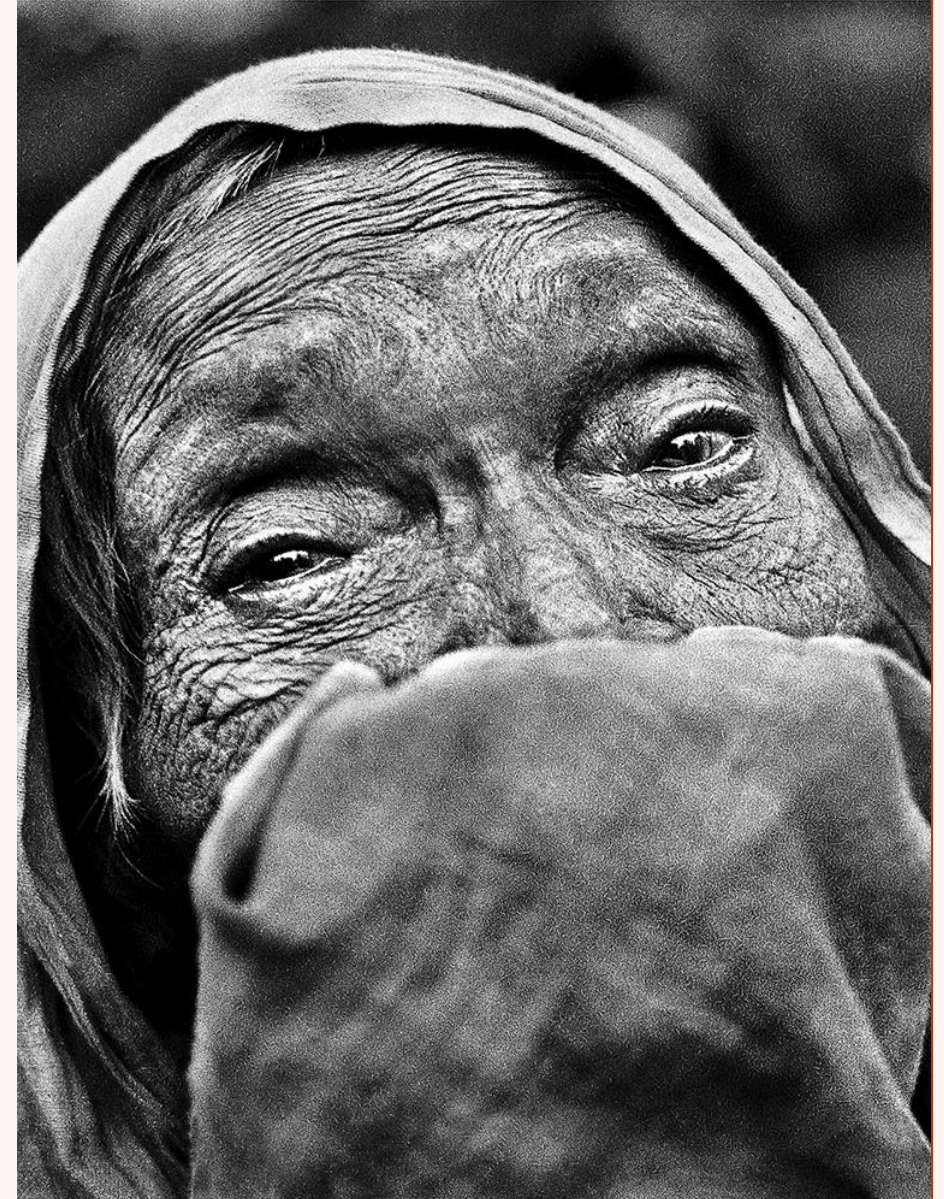
"Women's work outside the household alters how society values women."



- Economic contribution strengthens women's voice in:
 - Fertility decisions
 - Allocation of food, health, and education
- Mothers are less likely than fathers to discriminate against daughters
- **Key term – Household bargaining:**
Negotiation over resources and decision-making within families.
- **Quote-worthy:**
"When women gain voice within households, daughters are no longer treated as expendable."



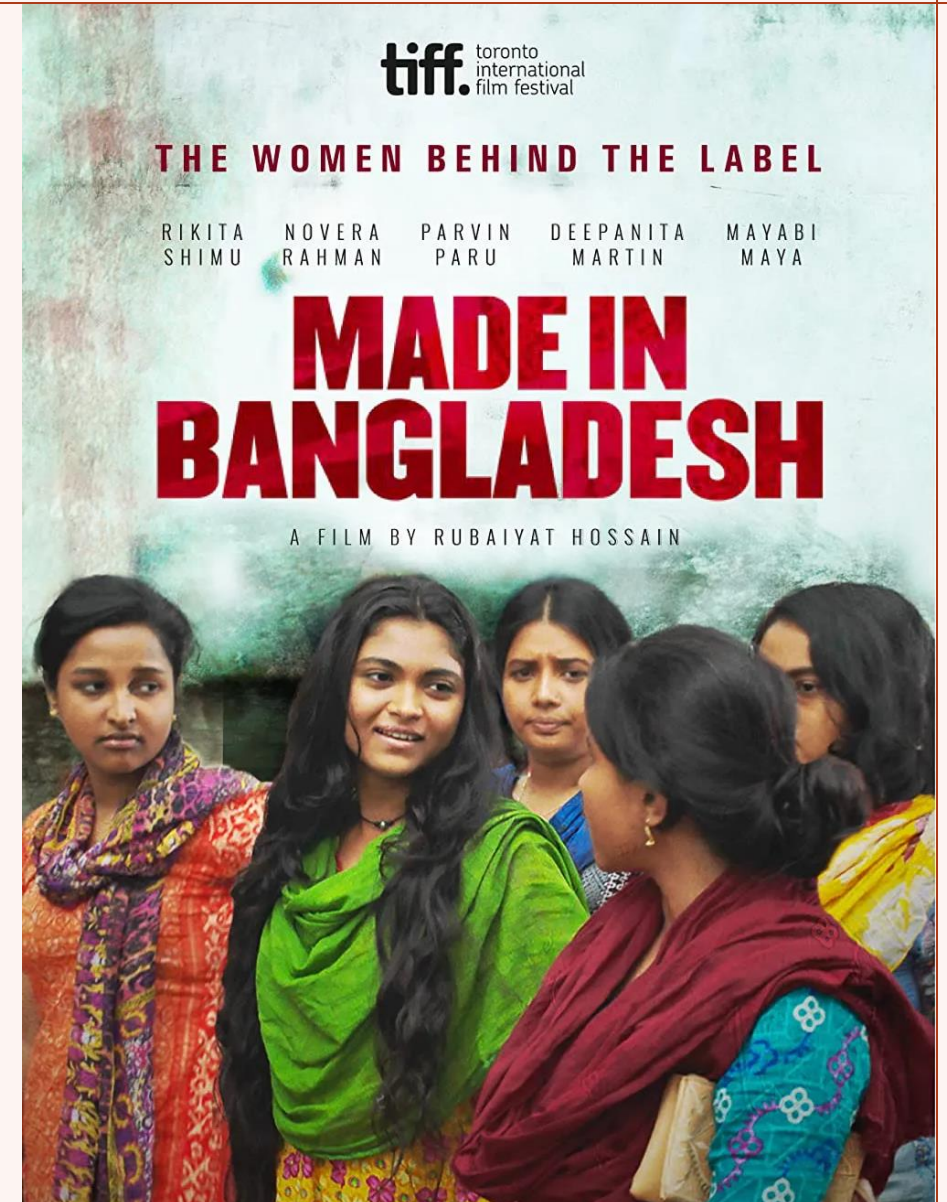
- In classic patriarchy, women rarely challenge norms openly
- Instead, they pursue **security within patriarchy**
- Producing sons ensures:
 - Status
 - Protection
 - Old-age security
- **Key term – Patriarchal bargain:**
Strategies women use to maximize security under patriarchal constraints.
- **Quote-worthy:**
"Women do not simply submit to patriarchy; they negotiate with it."



- Dependence on sons creates:
 - Strong son preference
 - Pressure for high fertility
- Reproductive behavior reflects **structural insecurity**, not irrational culture
- **Quote-worthy:**
"High fertility is best understood as a response to insecurity rather than tradition alone."



- New opportunities reduce dependence on sons:
 - Paid employment
 - Education
 - Social networks
- Women begin to renegotiate gender expectations
- **Quote-worthy:**
"The erosion of son preference reflects changes in women's material conditions."

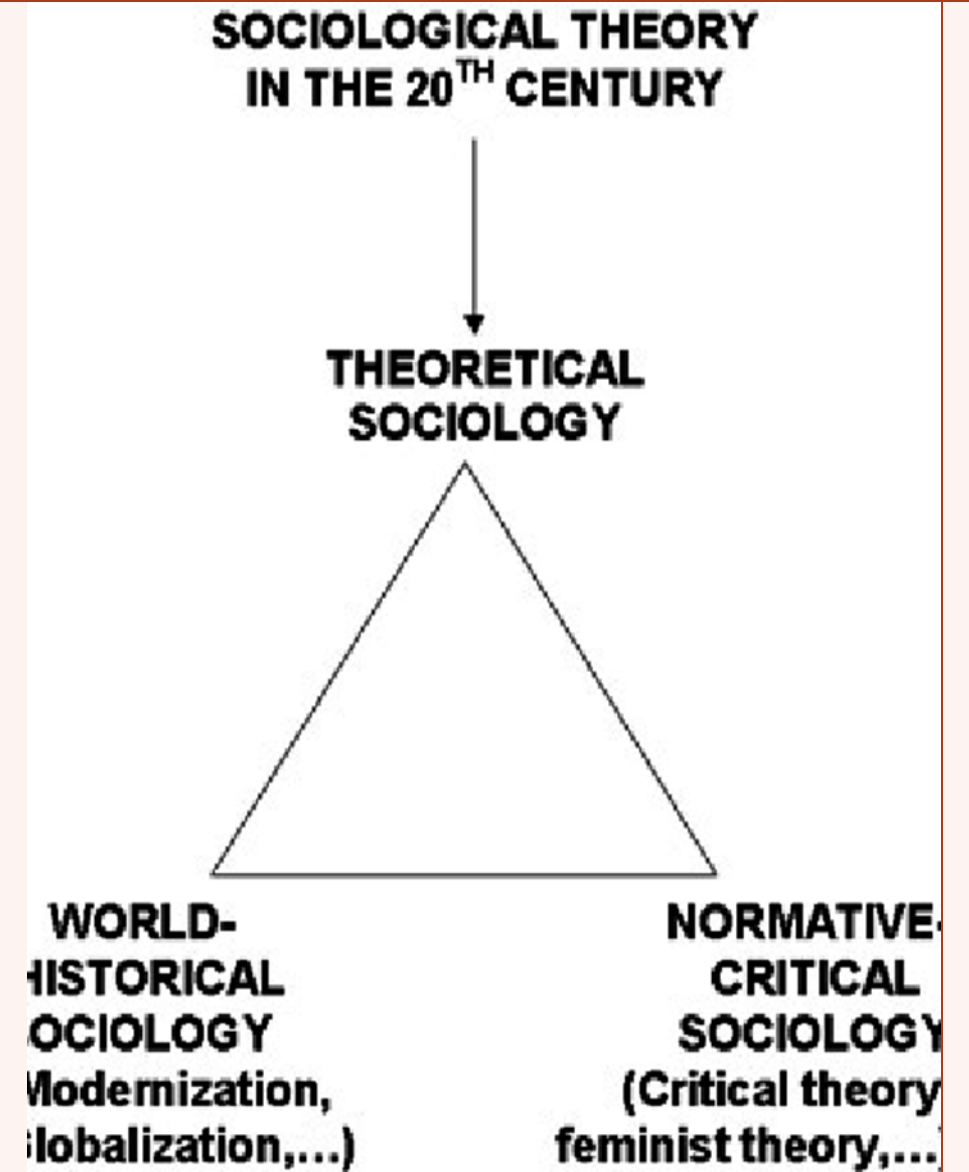
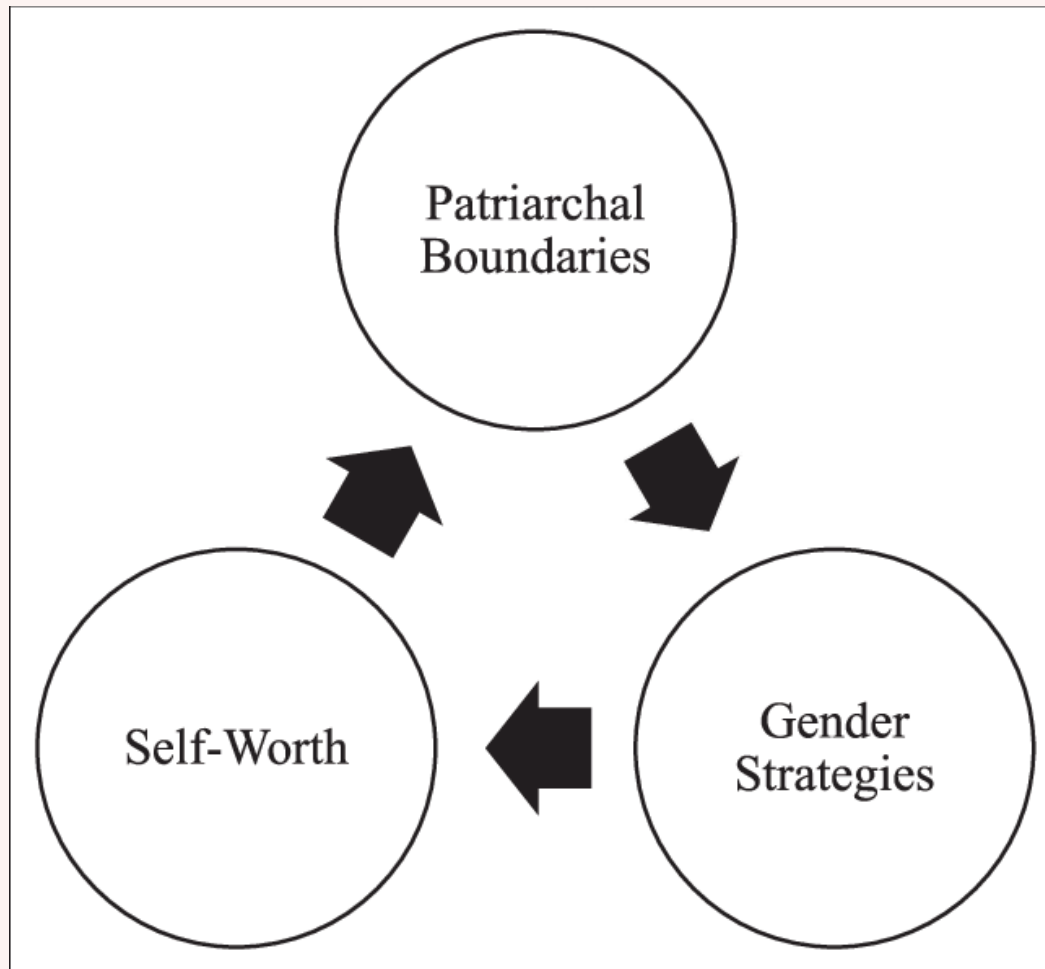


- Patriarchy is not dismantled overnight
- Change occurs through:
 - Incremental adjustments
 - Everyday negotiations
 - Accumulated effects over time
- **Quote-worthy:**
"Change within patriarchy occurs not through rupture, but through cumulative acts of renegotiation."



- Women's agency explains:
 - Declining fertility
 - Improved survival of girls
 - Revaluation of daughters
- Progress occurred **within patriarchy**, not after its removal
- **Quote-worthy:**
"Bangladesh's social progress was achieved not despite patriarchy, but through its gradual renegotiation."





THANK YOU

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